Dr S. Rajasekaran, editor-in-chief of the *Indian Spine Journal* and chairman of the Department of Orthopaedics, Trauma & Spine Surgery at Ganga Hospital, Coimbatore, agrees: "There is definitely an increasing trend of spine pain disorders—both lower back and neck—in people below the age of 40." The pattern of complaints is also becoming more complex. "Early onset of disc-related leg or arm pain (sciatica or cervical radiculopathy) is now being seen in the 20–35 year age group," he adds.

It's not just allopathic doctors raising concern. "Spinal issues in the youth should be a public health priority," says Dr Issac Mathai, founder of Soukya, a holistic health centre in Bengaluru. "Physical neglect and mental stress are creating a generation prone to spinal dysfunction far earlier than ever. The tragedy is that many delay seeking help, letting small, fixable problems turn chronic."

"Spinal deformities in youth can accelerate disc degeneration, trigger premature arthritis, chronic pain, even respiratory or neurological issues"

DR VIDYADHARA S.
Chairman and Head of Spine Surgery, Manipal Hospitals, Old Airport Road, Bengaluru

THE PAIN POINTS

Anatomically, the spine is one of the body's most intricate structures—both a pillar of the skeleton and a highway of nerves. Its stacked bones shield the spinal cord, the central channel for messages between the brain and the rest of the body. When trouble strikes here, the fallout can affect movement, sensation and everyday function for years.

At the very top sits the cervical spine—the neck. Remarkably mobile, it balances and moves the head, allowing us to swivel, tilt and nod. But hours bent over screens, sudden whiplash of the sort caused by fast braking or accidents, or simply the wear of age takes a toll on its flexibility, leaving it stiff, sending pain into the shoulders and arms, or triggering headaches that creep up from the base of the skull.

The cervical spine flows into the thoracic region, the upper and mid-back that anchors the ribcage. Built more for stability than motion, it often bears the strain of a slouched posture, weak supporting muscles or the brittle bones of osteoporosis. Pain here can radiate between the shoulder blades or wrap around the ribs, sometimes mimicking heart or lung issues.

Below lies the lumbar spine—the lower back and the body's workhorse. Bearing much of our weight and absorbing the shocks of daily movement, it is the epicentre of back pain globally. Strained muscles, bulging discs or arthritis can cause anything from morning stiffness to searing sciatica that shoots down the legs.

At the base, the sacrum and coccyx—triangular bones that lock into the pelvis, ending in the small tailbone—often go unnoticed until localised pain flares up, triggered by a fall or hours of sitting on a hard chair.

EMERGING NEW TREATMENTS

From robotic and augmented reality-guided surgeries to minimally invasive procedures and regenerative therapies, new spine treatments combine precision, safety and faster recovery for lasting relief

ROBOTIC SPINE SURGERY

Uses robotic arms and navigation systems to place screws or implants with millimetre-level accuracy, reducing risk to nerves and improving surgical precision

Cost: ₹4-9 lakh



TOTAL DISC REPLACEMENT

Replaces a damaged spinal disc with an artificial one, preserving natural motion instead of fusing vertebrae, which can help prevent stress on adjacent segments

Cost: ₹3-6 lakh

